

Trak · Character Feature

Draft approach for expert review — sports / educational psychologist · June 2026

How to use this document

This is our **draft thinking**, not a finished design. We are not psychologists — we've based this on published frameworks and our experience building a youth football app. We want your **honest, blunt review**: what's sound, what's risky, what to change, and where we're simply wrong. Throughout, lines marked "**Review:**" are the specific questions we'd value your input on, and they're consolidated at the end.

1. Context

- **Trak** is a football development app. The **coach is the primary user** — they log sessions and assess players. Today the **kids are passive**: the app is built for them, but they put in no work.
- We want to add a **character-building feature**, delivered to the kids, that (a) gives them an active role and (b) gives coaches a view of each player's **behavioural progress alongside performance** — "the complete player."
- **Football first**, one age cohort for the pilot. The coach controls delivery; **Trak owns the content** (including age-appropriateness).

2. Our intended approach

a. Frameworks we're leaning on

- **TPSR** (Hellison — Teaching Personal and Social Responsibility): 5 levels, self-reflection driven, with "transfer" beyond sport as the goal.
- **PCA "ROOTS"** (Rules, Opponents, Officials, Teammates, Self) for sportsmanship.
- **Rugby's codified values** (e.g. World Rugby's Integrity/Respect/Discipline; the age-grade "TREDs") as a model for naming and drilling conduct.

Review: Are these the right foundations for character development through youth sport? What's missing or outdated? Is there a stronger evidence base we should build on instead?

b. The value-set (draft)

Six values: **Composure · Respect · Effort · Teamwork · Responsibility · Sportsmanship**, with "**Transfer**" (carrying behaviour outside sport) as a cross-cutting goal rather than a 7th value.

Review: Are these the right values, the right number, and named in a way that lands with children? Would you add, cut, or rename any?

c. Delivery model — a "learn → apply → act" loop

- **Learn** — short flashcards (what a value looks like in football).
- **Apply** — situational-judgment scenarios (a dilemma; the kid chooses a response and gets feedback — never a grade).
- **Act** — a real-world challenge ("at training, do X without being asked"), marked done.

Review: Is this a credible behaviour-change loop for this age group? Does the "act/transfer" step need more scaffolding to actually change real behaviour?

d. Cadence

- A **weekly value theme**; **one short moment per logged session** (triggered when the coach logs training/match, so it matches how often they play — not a forced daily task); **optional extras**; a **weekly payoff** (recognition/badge). Format rotates so it isn't repetitive.
- **Spiral curriculum**: values repeat across seasons at increasing depth.

Review: Is this dose realistic for behaviour change — too little, too much? Is a session-triggered rhythm sensible, or is consistency (e.g. fixed weekly) more important?

e. Age-appropriateness — Trak's responsibility

The coach should **not** judge difficulty; Trak serves the right level automatically based on the team's age (which the app already stores). We plan a content matrix:

Value × Age band × Tier (the spiral)

Three developmental bands, with content complexity matched to how children reason about right/wrong at each stage (our reference points: Piaget's and Kohlberg's stages of moral development):

Band	Approx age	How morality is reasoned (our assumption)	Content style
Foundation	~6–9	Concrete, rule/authority-based	"The ref is in charge — when the whistle goes, we stop." Simple, short.
Development	~10–13	Fairness, intent, consequences emerging	Scenario: teammates shout at the ref — what do you do?

Youth	~14–18	Abstract, identity, principle, leadership	"Your captain is losing it with the ref." "A handball no one saw — own up?"
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Review: Are these bands and age ranges developmentally accurate? Is our mapping of content complexity to moral-reasoning stage correct? Are Piaget/Kohlberg the right anchors, or would you ground this differently? What concepts are *inappropriate* for the youngest band?

f. Assessment & progress — deliberately NOT graded

- The kid **self-reflects**; the coach **lightly observes and recognises**. We compare self-perception to coach observation as a growth conversation, not a score.
- Progress is shown as **streaks, badges, and demonstrated values** — and as a separate "character corner" on the player card. **Never a character score, never a ranking, never a deficiency label.**

Review: Is "no grading" the right call? Is self-reflection valid and useful at these ages (especially the youngest)? How should we handle the honesty problem — kids rating themselves generously or to please the coach?

g. Motivation & gamification (our biggest worry)

We plan to use badges, streaks, unlocks, and recognition to keep kids engaged.

Review: Does rewarding *good character* with extrinsic rewards risk undermining the intrinsic motivation we actually want (the over-justification effect / self-determination theory)? How do we make it engaging without crowding out genuine internalisation? Where's the line?

h. Anti-gaming / social desirability

We're aware kids may "perform" sportsmanship for points. Mitigations we're considering: reward **consistency and real-world action** over one-off taps, weight **coach corroboration**, and use **no public leaderboard**.

Review: Are these mitigations sufficient? What's the best way to encourage authentic behaviour rather than reward-chasing?

i. Safeguarding & wellbeing

This is children's behavioural data. Scenarios touch on conflict, mistakes, and losing. Reflections are private to the child and their coach (parents only later, with consent).

Review: Any emotional-safety risks in asking children to reflect on their own behaviour or engage with conflict/loss scenarios? Any content red lines? Consent/parental considerations?

3. What we will NOT claim

We won't claim the feature "fixes behaviour," reduces aggression, or guarantees outcomes. We want honest, evidence-aligned positioning.

Review: What can we **credibly** say this does? Where must we stay cautious?

4. The questions we most want answered (priority order)

1. Are the **frameworks and value-set** sound and complete?
2. Is the **age-banding** developmentally accurate, and the content-complexity mapping correct?
3. Is **self-reflection + no grading** the right approach for these ages — and how do we keep self-report honest?
4. Does **gamification undermine intrinsic motivation**, and how do we avoid that?
5. Are our **anti-gaming** mitigations enough?
6. How do we make **real-world transfer** actually happen?
7. Any **emotional-safety / safeguarding** red flags?
8. What can we **honestly claim** the feature achieves?

5. What we'd like from you

- Concrete changes to the value-set, age-banding, and the delivery loop.
- Any red lines or content cautions, especially for the youngest band.
- Pointers to evidence we should build on.
- Whether you'd be open to **reviewing the authored content** before it ships, and/or advising on an ongoing basis.